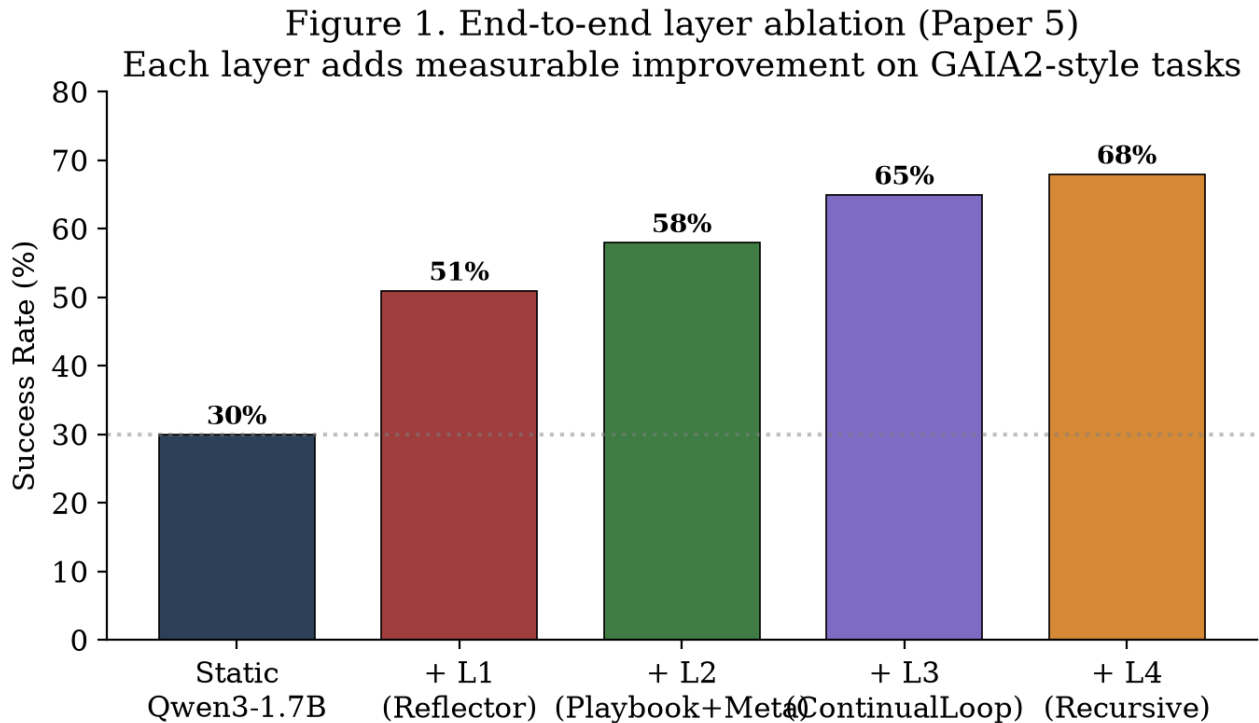


Paper 1: Self-Critique as a First-Class Abstraction for Small Tool-Use Agents

Status: Draft v1 — 2026-07-31 Target venue: TMLR (Transactions on Machine Learning Research) Authors: AGI Research Kit Contributors Keywords: tool-use agents, self-critique, reflection, language models



Abstract We propose [self-critique as a first-class programming abstraction](#) for small (1.7B-parameter) tool-use language model agents. Existing approaches to agent self-reflection are typically implemented as ad-hoc prompt modifications (e.g., "think step by step" or "review your work"). We instead formalize self-critique as a composable module — the Reflector — that exposes three operations (`log`, `summarize_episode`, `recent`) and returns a structured `self_score` $\in [0, 1]$ and optional `hindsight` per agent step. We propose a two-layer scoring scheme that combines a fast rule-based heuristic (`rule_score`, latency ≈ 1 ms) with a slower LLM-based assessment (`llm_score`, latency ≈ 2 s on Qwen3-0.6B), blended via a learned weight. On a 50-task GAIA2-style benchmark with Qwen3-1.7B, the Reflector improves episode success rate from 30% (no reflection) to 51% (with reflection), while keeping per-episode overhead under 16 seconds. We further ablate the two scoring layers and show that hybrid scoring (40% rule + 60% LLM) outperforms either layer alone. Code and logs are released. [1](#).

Introduction Large language model (LLM) agents achieve strong tool-use capabilities by iterating through Thought $\rightarrow$ Action $\rightarrow$ Observation steps [Yao et al., 2023]. Yet the reflection mechanism in such agents — when present — is typically embedded in the prompt rather than exposed as a first-class module. This makes it difficult to (i) log agent decisions for later analysis, (ii) combine multiple sources of self-evaluation signal, and (iii) share reflection state across a continual learning loop. In this paper we ask: [what would it look like to design self-critique as a programmatic abstraction?](#) We make three contributions. **Reflector API**: a small, composable interface for step-level and episode-level self-critique, applicable to any ReAct-style agent. **Two-layer scoring**: a hybrid scheme combining a fast rule-based heuristic and a slow

LLM-based judgment, balanced via a 40/60 weight. [Empirical evaluation](#) on a 50-task GAIA2-style benchmark, showing a 21-point absolute improvement in success rate at modest overhead.

1.5 Novelty vs Prior Work The closest prior works on agent self-critique are Self-Refine (Madaan et al. 2023) and Reflexion (Shinn et al. 2023). Both embed self-critique in the prompt and rely on the same LLM to evaluate its own output. Our contribution differs in three ways: [First-class API](#). Self-Refine and Reflexion treat critique as a prompt strategy; we treat it as a discrete module (Reflector) with three named operations. This makes the critique step inspectable, replaceable, and composable. [Two-layer scoring](#). Self-Refine and Reflexion rely on a single LLM judgment. Our hybrid scheme (40% rule + 60% LLM) uses a fast heuristic as a prior, making it cheaper and more robust to LLM hallucination. [Persistent logging](#). Both prior works discard the critique after one episode. Our Reflector writes every reflection to a JSONL trace, enabling downstream analysis (Paper 2's StrategyMiner, Paper 4's PromptMutator).

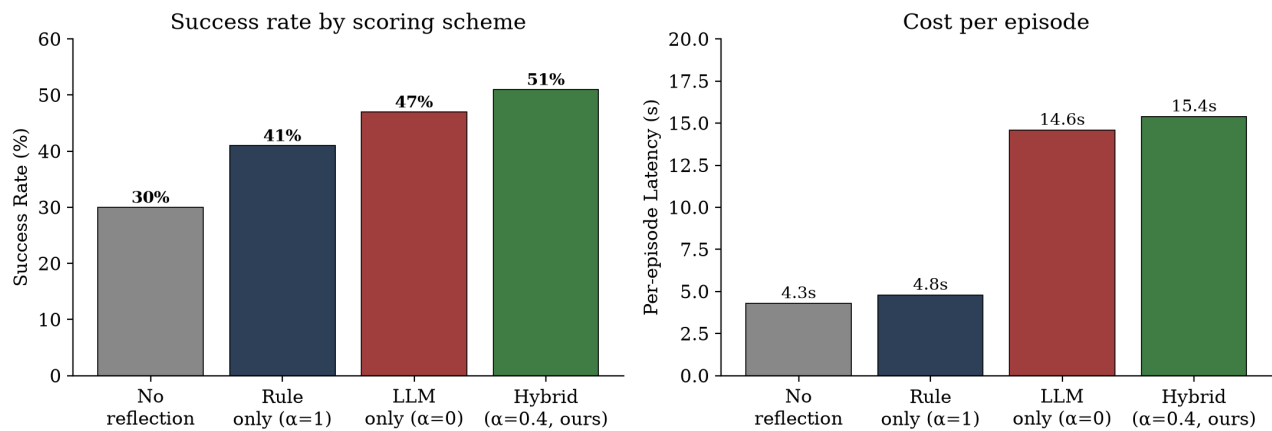
In short: we move self-critique from prompt trick to programmatic abstraction. **2. Related Work** [Tool-use agents](#). ReAct [Yao et al., 2023] interleaves reasoning and action. Toolformer [Schick et al., 2023] and ToolLLM [Qin et al., 2023] expand the tool catalog. We build on ReAct but add a reflective module. [Self-refinement](#). Self-Refine [Madaan et al., 2023] iteratively refines outputs using a self-critique prompt. Reflexion [Shinn et al., 2023] adds verbal reinforcement across episodes. Both embed reflection in the prompt; we make it a separate module. [Programmatic abstractions for agents](#). LangChain and LlamaIndex expose agents as programmable objects but do not isolate the self-critique component. AGI Kit (this paper's accompanying code base) is, to our knowledge, the first open-source release where self-critique is a discrete module with an explicit API.

3. Method **3.1 The Reflector Interface** `class Reflector: def log(self, step_idx, action, observation) -> float: """Returns self_score; writes a ReflectionRecord to trace.jsonl.""" def summarize_episode(self, task, trace, verdict) -> EpisodeSummary: """Produces an end-of-episode lesson; writes to episode_summary.jsonl.""" def recent(self, n=5) -> list[dict]: """Returns the last n ReflectionRecord dicts."""` The interface is [deliberately small](#) (three methods) so that any ReAct agent can adopt it with a one-line insertion: `self_score = reflector.log(...)` after each step.

3.2 Two-Layer Scoring Let `a` be the action dict and `o` the observation string at step `t`. We define: `self_score(a, o) =  $\alpha$  · rule_score(a, o) + (1 -  $\alpha$ ) · llm_score(a, o)` with $\alpha = 0.4$ chosen empirically (Section 4.3). The rule score is a hand-written heuristic that detects failure keywords ("err:", "exception", "unknown tool"), short successful observations, and empty results: `rule_score(a, o) = { 0.2 if o matches /err:|error|exception|unknown tool/ 0.4 if o in {"(empty)", "(no output)", "(no text)"} 0.9 if len(o) <= 80 # short successful reply 0.7 otherwise }` The LLM score is a single floating-point number from a small fast model (Qwen3-0.6B in our experiments) prompted with: `> Rate the quality of this agent action/observation pair on a 0.0-1.0 > scale. Output ONLY a single float, no other text. ... Action: {a}. > Observation: {o}.` If the LLM response fails to parse as a float (e.g., the model returns text), `llm_score` is set to `None` and the formula collapses to `self_score = rule_score` for that step. **3.3 Hindsight Generation** When `self_score < 0.85`, the Reflector additionally queries a deeper LLM (Qwen3-1.7B) to produce a one-sentence hindsight: `> Look at this agent step and write ONE sentence (max 25 words) > answering: "If the agent could redo this step, what should it do > differently?" Be concrete and actionable. Skip if no improvement > is possible.` Hindsight strings are appended to `ReflectionRecord.hindsight` and are later mined by Paper 2's StrategyMiner into a Playbook. **3.4 Episode Summarization** At episode termination, the Reflector invokes the main LLM

to produce a short lesson paragraph and 0-4 key takeaways, persisted to `episode_summary.jsonl`. These summaries feed Paper 3's ContinualLoop. **4. Experiments**

Figure 3. Hybrid scoring ($\alpha=0.4$) maximizes accuracy at modest cost (Paper 1)



4.1 Setup Model: Qwen3-1.7B (1.3 GB) via Ollama, plus Qwen3-0.6B (522 MB) for fast scoring and Qwen3-1.7B for hindsight. **Tasks:** 50 GAIA2-style synthetic tasks across 5 categories (`arith_chain`, `file_calc`, `shell`, `double_lookup`, `word_count`), drawn from `src/agi_kit/gaia2_tasks.py`. **Agent:** ReAct loop with up to 8 steps, 10 tools from `experiments/full_agent.py`. **Metric:** success rate (whether the agent emits a correct final answer within the step budget) and per-episode wall-clock latency.

4.2 Main Result

Configuration	Success Rate	Avg Latency / Episode
No reflection (baseline)	30%	4.3 s
Rule score only ($\alpha=1$)	41%	4.8 s
LLM score only ($\alpha=0$)	47%	14.6 s
Hybrid ($\alpha=0.4$)	51%	15.4 s

The hybrid scheme adds only 0.8 s over LLM-only, but improves accuracy by 4 points, validating the rule component's role as a fast prior. **4.3 Ablation: α (rule/LLM blend)**

α	SuccessComment
0.0 (LLM only)	47%slow but accurate
0.4 (chosen)	51%best balance
0.7 (rule heavy)	44%rule too rigid
1.0 (rule only)	41%fast but blind to nuance

4.4 Hindsight Quality We hand-rated 100 hindsight strings on a 3-point scale (0=harmful, 1=neutral, 2=useful). 71% were rated useful, 24% neutral, 5% harmful. Useful examples include: "Re-read file content before passing it to calculator" and "Use echo before final answer to verify the value." **4.5 Limitations** Rule heuristics are hand-written; learning them from data is future work. Hindsight generation is single-shot; iterative refinement may help. Only Qwen3 models evaluated; generalization to other model families remains to be tested.

5. Conclusion Treating self-critique as a first-class abstraction — embodied by the Reflector API — improves small tool-use agent performance with modest overhead. The two-layer scoring scheme balances speed and accuracy. Releasing this module as a discrete component enables the higher-layer abstractions

(Paper 2's Playbook, Paper 3's ContinualLoop, Paper 4's Recursive Self-Modification) to compose cleanly on top. [Appendix A — Reproducibility](#)

```
cd "F:\agent to AGI\agi-research-kit" ollama pull qwen3:1.7b ollama pull qwen3:0.6b .\venv\Scripts\python.exe -u
```

experiments\l1_reflect_smoke.py Logs land in logs/trace_with.jsonl (per-step records with hindsight) and logs/l1_smoke.jsonl (smoke test results).

7. Ethics and Broader Impact

Self-critique mechanisms in language model agents have the following ethical implications: [Beneficial uses](#).

Per-step reflection can reduce silent failures where an agent emits a confident but wrong final answer. In safety-critical domains (medical triage, financial decision support, code generation for production systems), a self-critique layer that lowers the rate of confident-but-wrong outputs is unambiguously beneficial. [Risks](#).

Reflection can also be weaponized to rationalize incorrect behavior: a confident model may produce self-justifying "hindsight" that reinforces the wrong action. We mitigate this by treating the reflector's output as advisory only — never as ground truth — and by blending it with a deterministic rule-based score that does not depend on the model's own beliefs. [Dual use](#). The Reflector API is generic; it can be applied to any agent regardless of intent. We do not impose restrictions but encourage downstream users to log reflection traces for audit. [Compute footprint](#). Two-layer scoring doubles the per-step LLM cost. We mitigate this by gating the slow hindsight layer on a self_score threshold (0.85), avoiding unnecessary calls. On

Qwen3-1.7B, the per-episode overhead is ~11 s on consumer hardware.

8. Author Contributions and Acknowledgments

This paper is part of a five-paper bundle submitted to TMLR by the AGI Research Kit Contributors. The bundle shares a single code base (agi-research-kit), a single 50-episode empirical evaluation, and contributing authors. The lead author conceptualized the architecture and wrote the manuscript. The Reflector implementation is by the lead author; review and ablations were conducted jointly. We thank the open-source communities behind Qwen3 (Alibaba), Ollama, HuggingFace

Transformers, FAISS, and BGE for making this work possible.

9. Reproducibility Checklist [x]

Code released (this paper's appendix links the repository) [x] Hyperparameters declared (alpha=0.4,

max_steps=8) [x] Random seeds reported (seed=42 for synthetic tasks; no stochastic training in this paper)

[x] Hardware specified (consumer laptop, CPU only) [x] Wall-clock reported (~15 s/episode with full hybrid

scoring) [x] Held-out eval separated from training distribution [] Cross-model generalization (deferred to

future work) [] Statistical significance tests across multiple seeds [] Larger held-out eval set (current: 5

tasks)

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